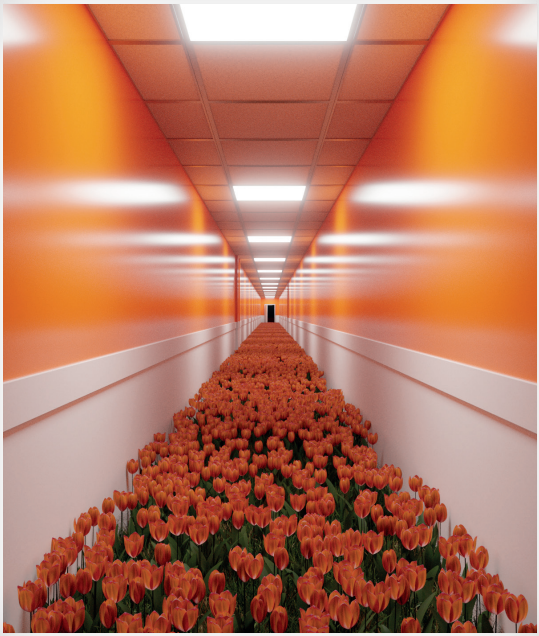
valentina tanni

exit reality

vaporwave, backrooms, weirdcore, and other landscapes beyond the threshold



"The Internet is an alien life form," declared David Bowie in 1999: today, the prophecy has come true, and our digital tools have become magical portals with mysterious properties, windows that overlook a dimension bordering between dream and reality.

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Beyond the screen mirrors we comfortably carry in our pockets, we have discovered a region haunted by strange presences—sometimes threatening, sometimes surreal, occasionally fascinating, and other times nonsensical. These are the same presences that, over the past fifteen years, have shaped what we now recognize as "internet aesthetics," that ensemble of subcultures, popular narratives, and visual and auditory languages through which the alien entity has finally revealed itself to humanity. The net then reveals itself for what it truly is: a threshold as physical as it is mental, where bizarre things happen, time is warped, and we find ourselves inhabiting an intermediate dimension, a territory that is "neither here nor there."

AKSIOMA NERO

Poetry

Exit Reality marks the first attempt to map a world imbued with disorienting hallucinatory qualities, a realm that appears to us as a parallel planet that has emerged from the depths of code-space. Starting from the advent of vaporwave, which infused the network's native imagery with spectral qualities in the early 2010s, Valentina Tanni takes us on a descent through the levels that traverse the silent horror of the backrooms, brushes against the obsession with sensory stimulation of ASMR, delves into the algorithmic surrealism of weirdcore, and lands in the exploration of pseudomagical practices such as reality shifting and memetic rituals. All the while, we remain comfortably seated before our screen, inside a battlestation ready to take off for a one-way astral journey, eternally trapped in the liminal space born from the now inseparable bond between human visions and Machine dreams.

Exit Reality
Vaporwave, Backrooms, Weirdcore,
and Other Landscapes Beyond the Threshold
by Valentina Tanni

Translated by:
Anna Carruthers

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exit reality

enter

post-modem life

One of the most important things you learn
from the internet is that there is no "them" out there.
It's just an awful lot of "us."
[Douglas Adams, 1999[1]]

I can still clearly remember the day my mother hid the modem. She picked it up, wound the cable around it, and took it away. It was seven in the morning, dim light filtering in through the window, and I watched her sleepily from my desk as the browser went offline. In actual fact, she would never have known how to disconnect me from the internet by herself: I'd told her how to do it. After yet another sleepless night in front of the screen, I'd said to her: take this thing away. I spent a couple of days in withdrawal, then I found it again: she'd hidden my 56k modem, a little gray box branded U.S. Robotics, under a copper pot in the fireplace. It was 1997. That was how the internet came into my life, and the lives of most of my generation. Via a contraption with four little lights that made weird noises and kept the phone line busy. In those days you weren't always connected: it was an activity you planned, normally in the evening, and there were essentially four things you could do, like the number of lights on the modem: surf the net, write emails, chat, and play games. The web was a predictable, orderly place, web pages were static, and there was only one search engine, Altavista, which indexed a small percentage of the already small amount of information available. It

1 Douglas Adams, "How to Stop Worrying and Learn to Love the internet," *The Sunday Times*, 1999, douglasadams.com/dna/19990901-00-a.html.

is hard to imagine now, but there was no such thing as social media; YouTube would not exist for another eight years, and Skype at least six. There were no videos or high-resolution images because there was not enough bandwidth, and computers were not powerful enough to transfer and process that amount of data. Despite these limitations, it was such a fascinating tool that we spent as much time as possible on it, pulling all-nighters, going without sleep, paying huge phone bills, and staring at the screen waiting for the pictures to load. The opportunities it offered, such as they were, felt incredible: you would chat just for the sake of communicating with people in far-off places, wrapped up in the thrill of being able to do it in real time. You'd open your inbox with a sense of anticipation (no newsletters or spam back then) and type random words into the search engine just to see *how many things came up*; you'd go carefully through website directories, opening the links divided by topic, making sure to work through them all, switching them from blue to purple, one by one. I swear there was a time when *finishing the internet* seemed almost possible. Instead, the more we surfed, the bigger it got; in a sense, it was our very presence that made it grow.

I have spent an immeasurable amount of time online: I have studied, written, played, and chatted on the internet; I have built friendships, seen communities form and disband, and new phenomena and languages arise and change, but most of all I have learned to appreciate the staggering diversity of human expression. Day after day, I have discovered that the rabbit hole is not just deep: it's *bottomless*. What keeps me hooked, even now—the

real core of my internet addiction—is the pleasure of experiencing the teeming activity of the world, sensing the presence of others, being constantly amazed at the complexity of the behaviors, words, sounds, and images that pour into the Web every minute.

In the space of twenty-five years, the scenario has slowly changed. Like the proverbial frogs in hot water, we have stayed in place while the temperature of the net has been gradually rising, trying to hold off privatization, censorship, surveillance, corporate overreach, and the power of the algorithm. Barely a quarter of a century on, we are immersed in a completely different techno-social ecosystem: no longer a niche inhabited by a few thousand, or even a few million, people, but a global infrastructure that is a key part of most people's lives. A monumental, self-aggregating edifice, a life form that feeds on billions of individual entities—human and non-human—distributed haphazardly throughout the net. This alien being is now a forge for cultural production on all levels: a hub and an outlet, a workshop and a platform, a wellspring and a touchpoint. Yet despite this, network-native artistic products, especially those of a collaborative nature, rarely reach institutional spaces or gain visibility on mainstream circuits. They are viewed as minor phenomena, subcultural movements destined for oblivion, or alternatively, they are systematically plundered by more influential fields such as fashion, film, and mainstream visual arts.

Nothing could be further from the truth. So-called "internet aesthetics" are not the periphery of contemporary art: they are its core. They are the most reliable

expressions of the zeitgeist because they are spawned by collective processes that involve millions of people. They influence, and also reveal, our view of the present and the conceptual tools we use to imagine the future.

We are all database animals
navigating the hyperflatness of the digital sphere.
[Hiroki Azuma, 2001[2]]

On the internet there is a site that was set up with the aim of cataloging these aesthetics. Aesthetics Wiki[3] is a collaborative project that was launched in 2018 and really took off in 2020, during the Covid-19 lockdown. According to official figures released by Fandom, the company that runs the platform, there are more than 250 contributors, and 57 percent of the site's users are aged between 18 and 24.

The site provides a definition of the term aesthetics in a section entitled "Aesthetics 101," starting from its historical origins, and recognizing its philosophical roots and connection to art history. It adds its own update to this: "Aesthetics have now come to mean a collection of images, colors, objects, music, and writings that creates a specific emotion, purpose, and community. All aesthetics have a background and history that has a variety of origins. For example, different historical periods, fictional genres,

2 Hiroki Azuma, *Otaku: Japan's Database Animals* (University of Minnesota Press, 2009).

3 Aesthetics Wiki, aesthetics.fandom.com/wiki/Aesthetics_Wiki.

subcultures, music genres, and national cultures can be considered aesthetics." It also makes another important point: "[T]here is currently no dictionary definition that captures the complexity of this phenomenon, which arose in the internet youth."

The aesthetics that, especially in the last fifteen years, have begun to populate the web are an elusive, complex, hard-to-define, creative, multimedia phenomenon; the speed at which they change and evolve makes it all but impossible to pin them down. One thing for sure is that this is a phenomenon generated by the "internet youth." With encyclopedic zeal, the wiki's authors have organized the entries alphabetically, but the content can also be browsed by image or color or decade. The most interesting category, however, is "suffix/family." To date, the most frequently used suffixes are "core," which occurs in as many as 158 aesthetics, "academia" (49), "punk" (41), "wave" (23) and "goth" (22).

The urge to categorize, and the modular dynamic—different features being assembled to form ever new combinations—are key aspects of internet culture, an inevitable consequence of inhabiting a cultural system structured around databases, tags, and hyperlinks. Each element—visual, sound, or text—represents a removable, catalogable, reusable brick to add to one's personal identity-building project. Online aesthetics are indeed linked to identity creation, individually but also within small and large communities, a trait that these movements have inherited from the glorious tradition of subcultures. On one hand, this can be viewed as very creative, because it offers endless scope to formulate new aesthetics with

a potentially infinite level of customization, yet on the other, there is always the risk that it will end up flattening out. Assembling one's identity from a set of keywords can in fact become a standardized process, reducing the individual's contribution to merely selecting from items in a pre-filled menu.

Indeed the main critiques of this cultural scenario focus on its homogenization and the commodification of its styles, understood as the visible expression of ideas, philosophies, and worldviews. In the blog *Aesthetics for Birds*, Anthony Cross writes: "The worry at this point is that by adopting an internet aesthetic, we run the risk of eliding the sort of aesthetic education and personal reflection that can go into developing a style of one's own [...]. My ultimate worry is that in trying to commit ourselves to one or another internet aesthetic, our role as aesthetic agents will ultimately be the narrow choice of which aesthetic we like—our job becomes one of picking from a number of pre-set packages."[4]

The same article also highlights another important aspect, namely that these trends emerge organically from online communities, "bottom-up" as it were. Unlike Instagram filters, for example, whose aesthetics are largely determined upstream by the platform itself, these cultural phenomena are spontaneous and unpredictable. Although some trends become so popular that they then

4 Anthony Cross, "Instagram Filters For The Self: Autonomy And Internet 'Aesthetics'," *Aesthetics for Birds*, September 3, 2020, aestheticsforbirds.com/2020/09/03/autonomy-and-internet-aesthetics.

get pigeonholed into a certain "canon"—a dynamic that makes for their rapid, effective commodification—the hundreds of subgenres, variations, and extensions of each style that spring up bear witness to the irrepressible vitality of these creative communities.

People should just exist on their own, doing their own interests and reblogging or posting the things they like. Others would soon see it, admire it, mimic it and then the trend catches on.
[Angela Yin, 2021[5]]

Exit Reality sets out to explore these aesthetic universes, join the dots, and uncover the forces that drive them. It is not a handbook (there is just far too much material), more a guide, a tour signposted by keywords. Each of these words sits atop a bubbling magma of text, images, and sound, a churning, swelling morass of multimedia narratives that engulfs everything it encounters.
The nostalgic, eerie sounds of vaporwave music, the silent, comforting horror of liminal spaces, the obsession with sensory stimulation that drives ASMR and ambience videos, the pseudomagical practices of reality shifting and memetic rituals—all these phenomena testify to a shift in perspective that regards how we perceive the world

5 Malavika Pradeep, "What are internet aesthetics and subcultures? Two Aesthetics Wiki members explain," *Screenshot*, June 5, 2023, screenshot-media.com/culture/internet-culture/aesthetic-versus-subculture.

and our role in it. Internet aesthetics are not just about escaping into virtual, fantasy dimensions, sophisticated get-out strategies hatched by a generation raised on the brink of an apocalypse. Rather, they can be seen as a set of experiments—messy, chaotic, syncretic experiments—gravitating around a single goal: to find new ways of relating to the concept of reality. Indeed, they continually test the boundaries of what we call "real," mingling science and magic, stories and technology, play and ritual. To the uninitiated, these might look like niche phenomena, but you only have to consider the staggering figures involved (tens, sometimes hundreds, of millions of views, comments, and interactions) to realize that they are anything but. The internet, which, over the years, like a gigantic, monstrous archive, has absorbed an incalculable mass of ideas, emotions, feelings, and fears, is the best place to observe them.

But the web is more than just a container; its very existence fuels these cultures and makes them possible. There are many factors at play, starting with the dizzying multiplication of viewpoints triggered by mass access to the means of content production and distribution: an ever-expanding kaleidoscope of voices, faces, opinions, and interpretations. *The world is too visible, the alternatives are endless, the identities unstable and fluctuating.* And adding to the sea of human visions are those produced by software and artificial intelligence, systems able to automatically and continuously generate ever-changing content.

To convey not just the look of these cultural objects, but also their emotional temperature, I have also included

the words of those involved: comments found under YouTube videos, on 4chan and Reddit message boards, on Twitter and Tumblr feeds. This "chorus" of voices is not incidental, quite the opposite: it offers essential insights into the role these movements play in people's lives. The words of the users, along with the many sources of inspiration I have collected from essays, novels, movies, music, and video games, are an integral part of the book; they are an echo, an extension, and sometimes a counter-melody. My writing has grown organically within this network of references, shaped by the plural, hypertrophic, hyperconnected nature of post-modem life.

Rome, summer 2023

exit reality

aesthetic

a wave of fluorescent nostalgia:
from vaporwave to frutiger aero

ghostly music

I've heard people say vaporwave tends to sound like an empty mall.
[Whoissnake, post on Reddit, 2021]

On 9 December 2011, the independent music platform Bandcamp released *Floral Shoppe*, a new album by the American artist Ramona Andra Xavier, also known as Vektroid, New Dreams Ltd., Laserdisc Vision, Sacred Tapestry, and by a host of other aliases. This time round, her chosen moniker was Macintosh Plus, and the album was released (in digital format alone, then on tape) by a small label called Beer On The Rug. On the cover, next to the title written in Japanese (フローラルの専門店; *Furōraru no Senmon-ten*), there is the sculpted head of the Greek god Helios, photoshopped onto a pink and black checkered floor. Behind Helios is a grainy image of the New York City skyline pre-9/11, with the Twin Towers clearly visible; it is a still from an old Fuji advertisement. The music, on the other hand, is a strange chill-out pop that makes extensive use of barely recognizable samples: sources range from the slick soul of the 1980s and 1990s (Diana Ross, Sade, Anita Baker, Pages) to actual elevator music (muzak, mood music, and so on), through vintage advertising jingles, video game soundtracks, and technological noise. The samples are slowed down, stretched out, distorted, and obsessively looped; the mood is dreamy and soulful, with some darker, more eerie vibes mixed in. The sound is muted, as if coming from afar, and this sense of remove plays a



[The cover of the album *Floral Shoppe* by Macintosh Plus, 2011]

key role in lending it a lingering nostalgic feel. It seems to be coming from some far-off *place*, but is actually from a distant *time*.

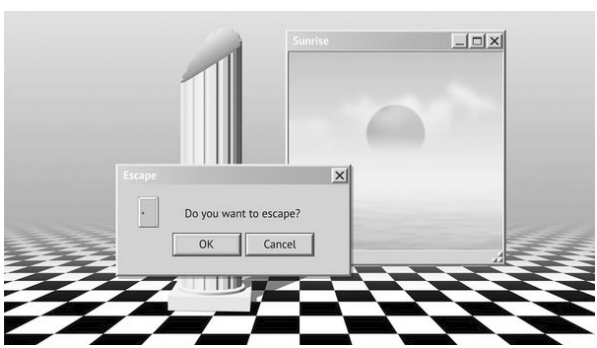
The critics were divided: for some it was a meaningless copy-and-paste of the worst airport lounge muzak. But for others, *Floral Shoppe* was a masterpiece, the album that, both musically and visually, definitively defines an aesthetic destined to dominate the digital underworld of the 1910s: the infamous vaporwave.

It is not clear where the name originated, though many point to the producer and musician Internet Club (aka Robin Burnett), who probably slipped it into the usual clouds of hashtags that accompany album releases on online platforms. It is a play on the term "vaporware," an expression used in the tech industry to define a hardware or software product that is announced but never actually brought to market: an item that remains

an idea, a marketing pitch, an *unfulfilled promise*—metaphorically speaking, a puff of "hot air."

Wikipedia calls vaporwave a "subculture" and an "internet meme" that is a "microgenre of electronic music" and a recognizable "visual style," characterized by a "nostalgic or surrealist engagement with the popular entertainment, technology and advertising of previous decades." Visually, it incorporates "early internet imagery, late 1990s web design, glitch art, anime, stylized Greek sculptures, 3D-rendered objects, and cyberpunk tropes," and it is full of anachronistic elements like Windows 95 interfaces, old Nintendo consoles, America Online advertisements, and bulky cathode ray tube TVs. Its signature colors are pink, light blue, light purple, and turquoise; mostly pastel shades with a touch of day-glo, aimed at conveying an idea of relaxation, chill-out, and a generic impression of comfort and softness. Images of shopping malls, waterfalls, house plants, checkered floors, clouds, and (of course) mist recur, interspersed with intrusive flashes of logos, brand names, commercials, icons of late technologized capitalism straight from the dreams of some Silicon Valley business angel back in the days when internet connections still plodded along at 56k. It is littered throughout with objects, writing, symbols, and sounds typical of the 1980s and 1990s; images of kids "surfing" on waves of pixels, or using a keyboard instead of a skateboard, perhaps on their way to an "internet café." Vaporwave is the first musical genre born and raised on the internet; it is transversal and global, and its references are rooted in the experience of online life, a new mode of interaction that gives rise to references,

aesthetics, and sensations capable of spanning cultural and sometimes even generational differences. While the music press, with few exceptions, appeared to ignore the phenomenon, tracks were constantly being released and listened to via sites such as SoundCloud, Turntable.FM, Tumblr, and Reddit, in addition to the aforementioned Bandcamp. In line with the identity fluidity typical on the web, most of the albums were released anonymously or under cryptic-sounding pseudonyms: DJ Internet Visions, Ecco Unlimited, Luxury Elite, Blank Banshee, t e l e p a t h テレパシー能力者, and so on. This highlighted the deliberately impersonal nature of this type of music, while at the same time reinforcing the sense of mystery and suspension. Perhaps these sounds were not actually made by anyone. Perhaps music is a living entity, regurgitated from the past, coming to us through some space-time wormhole. Perhaps music is a ghost.



[A vaporwave-style graphic, found image]



Fig. 25

[Traumacore is a kind of therapeutic art form, channeling strong emotions, sufferings, negative experiences, abuses, and repressed energies (Fig. 25). However, in traumacore content, the traumatic event is never explicit; instead, it is evoked through symbols and (rare) words (Fig. 26).]

Fig. 26



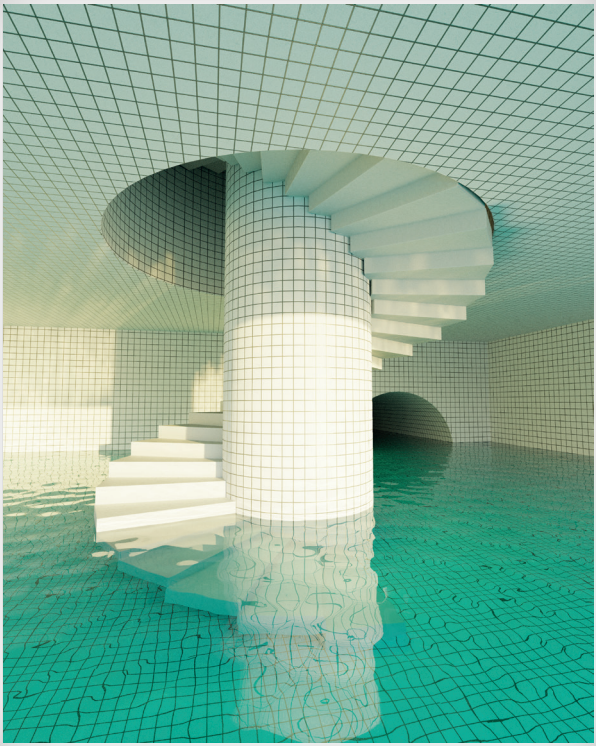


Fig. 13

[Jared Pike is a New York-based artist who specializes in 3D graphics. His renderings, which depict partially submerged imaginary architecture, are wildly popular. The series, started in 2021 and still in progress, is called *Dream Pool* (Fig. 13 shows *Dream Pool 10*, 2021).]

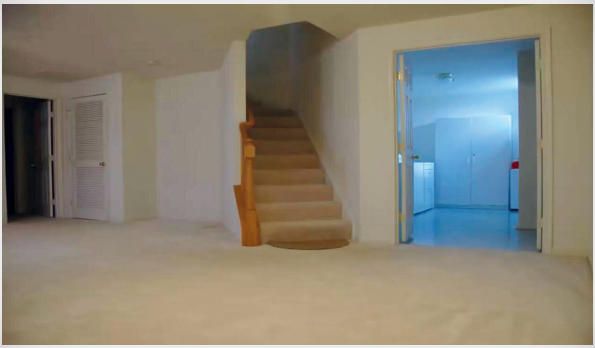


Fig. 11

[One of the most famous photographs of the liminal genre depicts an empty domestic environment, with a staircase in the center, illuminated by unnatural light (Fig. 11). In some cases, liminal spaces rise above the eerie to border on the terrifying, for example in Fig. 12, which depicts a swimming pool with greenish water and ominously anthropomorphic nozzles. The photo, found online, was taken at the Ingul Sanatorium, a hotel with a spa located in Mikolayv, Ukraine.]

Fig. 12



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For individual orders and information:
distribution@neroeditions.com | aksioma@aksioma.org

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